DAVID RACCUGLIA

Career, commercial achievements and international industry influence

Research profile | Prepared for Johnny Shanahan, Barber Republic | 1 November 2026

Executive assessment

David Raccuglia has substantial credibility as a barber, salon entrepreneur and international brand builder. His defining achievement is founding American Crew and helping expand the modern professional men's grooming category. His career also encompasses professional education, creative direction, portrait photography and documentary filmmaking.

The evidence supports a career built on practical knowledge of the trade, a clear view of an underserved customer, and sustained work in brand identity and professional education. American Crew subsequently reached international scale under successive teams and corporate owners. [1-5]

The strongest documented credentials

Founder of American Crew: launched in Chicago in 1994 with six products. [1, 2]

International brand scale: American Crew reported distribution through more than 30,000 salons, barbershops and authorised retailers across 50 countries in 2022. [3]

Category leadership: in 2023, the brand announced a world number-one premium men's hair ranking, citing Euromonitor retail sales data for 2022. [4]

Senior creative and education leadership: appointed Creative Director and Global Head of Education at American Crew in 2022. [3]

Reported Reuzel founding involvement: trade publication Glossy names him among the brand's five founders. [6]

Scope: This profile distinguishes company-reported achievements, first-person career accounts, independent trade reporting and assessment. Historical distribution and appointment figures are dated; they are not verified current figures.

1. From barbering to international education

Raccuglia grew up in LaSalle, Illinois. He credits his childhood barber, Bob Di Angelo, with inspiring his career. After barber college, he returned to work in Di Angelo's shop. [1]

He broadened his training at Pivot Point Academy in Chicago, worked briefly at Vidal Sassoon and moved to London to teach precision haircutting at Jingles Hair Academy. In his career interview, he recalled meeting Robert Lobetta, Anthony Mascolo and Trevor Sorbie during that period. By 1985 he was working at the New York Jingles Academy, followed by a move to San Francisco. [1]

Why it matters: his understanding of professional grooming developed through practical work, teaching and exposure to different markets before he launched a product business.

2. Salon entrepreneurship: Art + Science

After returning to Chicago, Raccuglia opened Art + Science with Laurence Hegarty. Trade reporting dates the first Evanston storefront to 1989. The business became an early Aveda Concept Salon, giving him experience of salon operations and the relationship between services, education and product retail. [1, 7]

Art + Science also helped establish enduring professional relationships. Paul Wilson, who became American Crew's global artistic director, described meeting Raccuglia through the industry and subsequently working on Crew's photographic shoots and shows. [7]

3. American Crew: identifying the opportunity

American Crew launched in Chicago in 1994. Its first six products were Daily Shampoo, Daily Conditioner, Texture Cream, Firm Hold Styling Gel, Light Hold Styling Gel and Pomade. [2]

Raccuglia identified growing interest in deliberate male grooming, alongside a shortage of professional products and marketing designed specifically for men. He also recognised renewed interest in traditional barbering. A Japanese water-based pomade, Cool Grease, helped inspire his thinking. [1, 8]

His commercial achievement was recognising an underserved customer and building a distinctive professional brand around that customer. Some promotional accounts credit him with creating men's grooming. The more defensible description is that he helped pioneer and popularise its modern professional category.

4. Commercial scale and category recognition

2014: American Crew reported distribution in more than 30,000 salons across over 40 countries. [2]

2022: the company reported distribution in more than 30,000 salons, barbershops and authorised retailers across 50 countries. [3]

2023: American Crew announced that it ranked as the number-one premium men's hair brand worldwide, citing Euromonitor International's Beauty and Personal Care 2023 edition, using 2022 retail value sales. The stated research covered 45 countries estimated to be the largest premium haircare markets. [4]

These are meaningful indicators of the scale achieved by the brand he founded. Distribution figures are company-reported. The ranking relates to a defined category and dataset; it should retain those qualifications. The later success also reflects the work of management teams, distributors and corporate owners.

5. Education as a route to adoption

In a 2019 interview, Raccuglia described education as central to American Crew's growth. Collections, imagery and teaching helped professionals develop the skills and confidence to cut and style men's hair. Expansion happened progressively across salons, cities and countries. [5]

The international All-Star Challenge provided a further professional connection point. Raccuglia served on its global judging panel alongside industry and editorial figures. Winners gained industry exposure and professional photographic opportunities. [9]

Assessment: he has experience building adoption through professional trust, education and visible examples of good work. This is particularly relevant to businesses asking barbers and shop owners to change established habits.

6. Continued leadership after the founding period

2014: American Crew announced his return as a creative consultant, including campaign photography and work with marketing and education teams. [2]

2022: his role expanded to Creative Director and Global Head of Education, covering global creative direction and education. [3]

2023: he was quoted as founder and creative director in the announcement of the premium men's hair ranking. [4]

These are dated appointments and announcements. His precise current contractual role has not been independently established for this profile.

7. Photography, visual identity and recognition

As American Crew's campaign photographer, Raccuglia contributed directly to the brand's visual identity. He described his initial aim as representing the haircut properly and making the campaigns distinctive. Photography subsequently became a separate professional career. [3, 8]

His professional biography lists portraits of Jack Nicholson, Ray Charles, James Brown and Yoko Ono, alongside projects involving blues musicians, folk artists, American quilters and Tibetan refugees. It also lists the books *Darker Blues* and *Portrait of the Culture in Exile*. These credits are reported in his own biography. [10]

The Indigo Design Award listing for American Crew's *25th Year Book* credits him as creative director and photographer, alongside designer and writer Marcos Chavez. This is a credited team achievement. [11]

8. Reuzel: a second grooming-brand connection

Glossy names David Raccuglia and Rob Wilcox among Reuzel's five founders, alongside Laurence Hegarty, Robert-Jan Rietveld and Leen Bergmann, dating the brand's founding to 2014. Reuzel's own consumer history emphasises Leen and Bertus and their Rotterdam barbering roots. The accounts describe different aspects of the founding story. [6, 12]

The supported conclusion is that David has reported founding involvement in a second internationally recognised professional grooming brand. His precise ownership, responsibilities and current authority should be confirmed directly before being specified in investor materials.

9. Documentary filmmaking

Purvis of Overtown: the International Documentary Association identifies Raccuglia and Shaun Conrad as directors of the documentary about artist Purvis Young and the Miami neighbourhood that shaped his work. Raccuglia described developing the project from photography and filming over several years. [13]

The Murders at Starved Rock: HBO's 2021 series drew on his lengthy investigation of a murder case prosecuted by his father. HBO described him as having spent 15 years examining the case. The series was directed by Jody McVeigh-Schultz and produced by Mark Wahlberg's Unrealistic Ideas; David should not be described as its sole director or producer. [14]

These projects demonstrate sustained creative work outside grooming. They do not establish that their participants are available to him as business contacts.

10. Acquisition history: what can be claimed

American Crew became part of The Colomer Group, which Revlon acquired in 2013. Revlon's completion announcement put the adjusted cash purchase price at approximately **US$665 million**. The acquisition included several brands, including Revlon Professional, CND and American Crew. [15]

The figure relates to the wider Colomer business. It cannot be described as American Crew's standalone sale price or Raccuglia's personal exit proceeds. This research did not establish a reliable public figure for his personal proceeds, wealth or American Crew's standalone revenue.

Relevance to Barber Republic

Trade understanding: his barbering and salon experience provides relevant knowledge of the people who would use the platform.

International brand building: American Crew provides evidence of experience taking an industry insight into a business that reached international scale.

Professional adoption: his education background may help with earning trust and explaining a new working model.

Creative judgement: his work in positioning and photography may support a clear, credible industry identity.

His international career provides a credible basis for expecting substantial professional relationships. The number of introductions, outlets or active partners he could bring to Barber Republic remains to be established directly. American Crew's distribution footprint cannot automatically be counted as Barber Republic's reachable network.

Suggested factual profile for investor materials

David Raccuglia is the founder of American Crew, the professional men's grooming brand launched in Chicago in 1994. The brand reported distribution across 50 countries and more than 30,000 professional and retail outlets in 2022. A trained barber, salon entrepreneur, photographer and creative leader, Raccuglia was appointed American Crew's Creative Director and Global Head of Education in 2022. [3]

Assessment: serious interest from David represents a meaningful endorsement from someone with directly relevant experience. Its practical investment value depends on an agreed role, specific commitments and permission to describe his involvement publicly. This profile does not itself establish an appointment, partnership or endorsement of Barber Republic.

Sources and further reading

All links below are clickable. Sources were consulted for the research accompanying this report on 1 November 2026. Company announcements are identified as such; interviews contain first-person accounts.

[1] Modern Salon - Choose Beauty: David Raccuglia (2 July 2014)

[2] American Crew announcement - return as creative consultant (10 April 2014)

[3] American Crew announcement - Creative Director and Global Head of Education (13 October 2022)

[4] American Crew announcement - global premium hair ranking (10 May 2023)

[5] Salon Magazine - 25 Years and Beyond (1 March 2019)

[6] Glossy - Liquid Death and Reuzel collaboration; founding team

[7] American Salon - Art + Science and Paul Wilson (9 April 2019)

[8] Barbering Today - All American: The Man Behind the Brand (8 July 2022)

[9] American Crew announcement - All-Star Challenge global judging panel (2014)

[10] David Raccuglia - professional biography

[11] Indigo Design Award - American Crew 25th Year Book credits

[12] Reuzel - official brand history

[13] International Documentary Association - Purvis of Overtown filmmakers

[14] HBO / Warner Bros. Discovery - The Murders at Starved Rock announcement

[15] Revlon / SEC - completion of Colomer acquisition (9 October 2013)